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DSL R Test

HOW WE TESTED

Our test of a DSLR basically breaks down into two categories: Imaging/Video Performance and Ergonomics/Build. Most aspects such as AF performance, WB presets, etc., would come under Image Performance, while the Build and comfort of holding the camera is part of the latter.

Our image and video performance test further breaks down into "Outdoor/Real World shots" and "Studio Test." In the Real World Image and Video Test, we tested for Dynamic Range by shooting a scene that contained subjects that were well lit, in shadow and subjects that were black in color. We tested for color and contrast by shooting a scene of foliage, while making sure that the scene was well lit and also incorporated the right kind of subjects. We chose to shoot potted plants, to see what kind of contrast and colors the sensors will resolve for the leaves and the pots. For low light performance we cranked up the ISO for 6400 and shot a street that's littered with towering

trees, cars and street lights. In our studio test, we measure the ISO performance and details using our standard test shot scene. We lit it evenly and shot at f/8 for optimum sharpness, depth of field and elimination of any other lens-related features that could impact the result. We shot all our shots with a 50mm lens at f/4 for outdoor shots and f/8 for studio shots.

Focus tracking was tested by getting an unwilling friend to drive our car right to left for a distance of 100 meters as we used the camera's tracking mode to shoot the images of the car in burst mode.

Ergonomics and build are a personal preference, but our goal was to see how much comfort remained in holding the camera after having used it for a couple of hours. We also gave higher points for how well our hands would fit around the grip of the camera, along with how much wiggle room our fingers had once they were wrapped around the grip.

set them apart. For example, the D3200 is the first entry level DSLR to sport a 24 megapixel count. The newly released Canon 650D sports the second highest pixel count in our test with an 18 megapixel sensor while the D5100 and the A57 were both pegged in at 16 megapixels.

Another important component of the feature set is the AF system. It's probably the most used feature on a DSLR, after the sensor itself. DSLRs have traditionally continued to use the contrast based detection system, due its high accuracy, but Sony has powered its A57 with a phase detect AF system.

While it does help the Alpha lock focus quicker than contrast based AF's, it suffers quite a bit in low light. Then steps in Canon with their 650D, which rocks a bunch of never before seen features, including the world's first hybrid phase-contrast detect AF system in a DSLR. This sets the 650D apart from the rest of the contenders, as it combines best of both the worlds into one AF system, which performed quite well. Interestingly, the 650D offers the least amount of focus points (9), while the Nikon brothers have 11 points for AF selection and the Alpha has 19 of them.

While this might seem like an impressive win for the Alpha, the kicker comes when you realize that the 650D's AF point system is right out of the 60D, that is, all the 9 focus points are cross type. Cross type AF points are sensitive to information in both the horizontal and vertical axes, allowing it to not only acquire focus, but even track. The Nikons have just one of these (the center point) and the Alpha 57 has 3. This is definitely a win for the 650D. In our assessment, the 650D topped the charts as far as features were considered, with the highest native ISO sup-

port, stereo mics for recording audio and once again a world first - a touchscreen on a DSLR. The touchscreen, which can control every aspect of the camera, along with having a touch-shutter, functions very smoothly, almost as good as any high end smartphone.

Ergonomics and Build

This is probably one of the most subjective aspects of a camera. If your hands are big, then entry level DSLRs won't fit well and if your hands are small, then the semi-professional and professional cameras might seem too bulky. Then there's the question of button placement's intuitiveness, etc.

We felt that again, the Canon 650D has the best build and ergonomics in this category, with the Alpha 57 and Nikon D5100 in a close second. Besides having a comfortable grip, the shutter button's placement follows the natural curve of the index finger, while on the rest, we needed to arch our finger a little higher to press the shutter button. We also felt that the 650D's minimal number of buttons was a major plus, probably because the touchscreen allows instant access to all the features. Whatever buttons were on the camera, for example, the ISO button was in easy reach, while on the D5100 and D3200, you need to first press a button

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